

31 Aaron

Moses' older brother and spokesman, and the first high priest of Israel.

Aaron was three years older than Moses, and God gave him to his brother as a voice when Moses said he could not speak well. Together they stood before Pharaoh, and Aaron's rod swallowed the magicians' rods. At Sinai he became Israel's first high priest, the man who would bring the people's offerings to God and God's blessing to the people. Yet the same Aaron made the golden calf, joined Miriam in criticizing Moses, and shared Moses' failure at Meribah. His life shows both the dignity and the weakness of priesthood. The New Testament uses his office to explain the work of Christ, a greater high priest.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Aharon</i> . Its meaning is uncertain
Family	Son of Amram and Jochebed; brother of Moses and Miriam (Exodus 6:20; Numbers 26:59)
Wife and sons	Elisheba; sons Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar (Exodus 6:23)
Office	Israel's first high priest (Exodus 28:1; Leviticus 8)
Lifespan	123 years; he died on Mount Hor in the fortieth year after the Exodus (Numbers 33:38–39)
Key people	Moses, Miriam, Nadab and Abihu, Korah, Eleazar, Hur
New Testament	Luke 1:5; Acts 7:40; Hebrews 5:4; 7:11; 9:4

"The LORD bless thee, and keep thee: The LORD make his face shine upon thee, and be gracious unto thee: The LORD lift up his countenance upon thee, and give thee peace."

Numbers 6:24–26, KJV

The life of Aaron

Dates are approximate (BC), on the early Exodus date, c. 1446 BC; the late date moves them about 185 years later. Ages from Exodus 7:7 and Numbers 33:39.

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| c. 1529 BC
<i>Birth</i> | ● Born in Egypt
Aaron is born to Amram and Jochebed, three years before Moses. <i>Exodus 6:20; 7:7</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Age 83</i> | ● Meets his brother
Aaron meets Moses at the mountain of God, and they tell Israel's elders what God has said. <i>Exodus 4:14-16, 27-31</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Age 83</i> | ● Before Pharaoh
His rod swallows the magicians' rods, and he stretches it out to bring the first plagues. <i>Exodus 7:1-20; 8:5-6, 16-17</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Wilderness</i> | ● Holds up Moses' hands
At Rephidim Aaron and Hur hold up Moses' hands until sunset, and Israel wins. <i>Exodus 17:8-13</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>At Sinai</i> | ● The golden calf
He sees the God of Israel with the elders, but later gives in and makes a golden calf. <i>Exodus 24:9-11; 32:1-6</i> |
| c. 1445 BC
<i>Second year</i> | ● Ordained high priest
He offers the first sacrifices, and fire comes from the LORD; that day Nadab and Abihu die. <i>Exodus 40:17; Leviticus 8:1-10:7</i> |
| c. 1445 BC
<i>Hazereth</i> | ● Speaks against Moses
With Miriam he criticizes Moses, then pleads for her when she is struck with leprosy. <i>Numbers 11:35; 12:1-12</i> |
| c. 1406 BC
<i>Age 123</i> | ● Dies on Mount Hor
His garments are put on Eleazar, and Israel mourns him thirty days. <i>Numbers 20:23-29; 33:38-39</i> |

Key activities

Some events, such as Korah's rebellion and the budding rod, are undated in Numbers.

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- I Spoke for Moses.** "I know that he can speak well." *Exodus 4:14-16; 7:1-2*

 - 2 Worked signs before Pharaoh.** He threw down his rod and stretched it over Egypt's waters. *Exodus 7:10-12, 19-20*

 - 3 Held up his brother's hands.** With Hur he held up Moses' hands all day at Rephidim. *Exodus 17:10-12*

 - 4 Saw God on the mountain.** He went up Sinai with the elders, and they saw the God of Israel and ate and drank. *Exodus 24:1, 9-11*

 - 5 Made the golden calf.** "I cast it into the fire, and there came out this calf." *Exodus 32:1-6, 21-24*

 - 6 Was clothed for glory.** He wore the ephod, the breastplate, and "HOLINESS TO THE LORD." *Exodus 28:1-38; Leviticus 8:6-12*

 - 7 Blessed the people.** After the first sacrifices he lifted his hands and blessed Israel, and God's fire consumed the offering. *Leviticus 9:22-24; Numbers 6:22-27*

 - 8 Held his peace.** When fire killed Nadab and Abihu, "Aaron held his peace." *Leviticus 10:1-3*

 - 9 Challenged Moses.** He and Miriam asked, "Hath the LORD indeed spoken only by Moses?" Then he begged Moses to pray for her. *Numbers 12:1-12*

 - 10 Stopped a plague.** He ran with his censer into the camp, "and he stood between the dead and the living; and the plague was stayed." *Numbers 16:46-48*

 - 11 Was confirmed by a budding rod.** Among twelve rods, his alone budded, blossomed and bore almonds overnight. *Numbers 17:1-10*

 - 12 Handed on the priesthood.** On Mount Hor his garments were placed on Eleazar before he died. *Numbers 20:25-28*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Aaron.

Old Testament

Exodus 28–29; Leviticus 8–10	His garments and ordination
Deuteronomy 9:20	Moses prayed for him after the calf
Deuteronomy 10:6	His death at Mosera, probably near Hor
Psalms 77:20	God led his people "by the hand of Moses and Aaron"
Psalms 133:2	His anointing a picture of unity
Micah 6:4	God sent "Moses, Aaron, and Miriam"

New Testament

Luke 1:5	Elisabeth is "of the daughters of Aaron"
Hebrews 5:4	Called of God, "as was Aaron"
Hebrews 7:11–28	Christ a priest after Melchisedec, not Aaron
Hebrews 9:4	His budded rod kept in the ark
Echo: Hebrews 4:14–16	Christ the "great high priest"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Aaron explain the golden calf to Moses (Exodus 32:21–24)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God still made Aaron high priest after the calf?
3. *Apply:* Where are you tempted to give people what they want instead of what is right?
4. *Apply:* Aaron and Hur held up Moses' hands. Whose hands could you hold up this week?